FUNCTIONAL GUIDE

Care Billing Module

How completed care visits turn into carer pay and funder invoices.

VERSION	3.0 · Simple Guide
FOR	Product, care operations, and finance teams
BASED ON	How Birdie, The Access Group, Nourish, CareLineLive & Nursebuddy work

Key terms

The words used throughout this document, in one place.

People and roles

Term	Short definition
Carer	The person who delivers the care visit and gets paid for it.
Service user (client)	The person who receives the care.
Funder (payer)	Whoever pays for the care — family, local authority, NHS, or the person themselves.
Local authority (council)	A council that funds care for eligible people.
NHS / ICB	Health-service funder, usually for complex or health-related care.
Client contribution	The share of the cost paid by the client or their family.
Branch	A local office or area within the care provider.

Rates and rate cards

Term	Short definition
Rate card	A set of rules for working out money.
Pay rate card	The rules for what the carer earns.
Charge (invoice) rate card	The rules for what the funder is billed.
Hourly rate	A price for each hour of care.
By-length rate	One set price for the whole visit, based on how long it is.
Fixed rate	A single set price for a block of care, like a sleeping night.
Service-type rate	A rate for a type of care, like complex care or companionship.
Multiplier	A number that raises a rate, e.g. 2× on a bank holiday.
Uplift	A percentage rise applied to a whole rate card at once.
Override	A special rate for one client, on top of or instead of the normal rate.

Visits and time

Term	Short definition
Visit (call)	A single scheduled period of care.

Term	Short definition
Check-in / check-out	The verified record of when the carer arrived and left.
Planned time	The scheduled length of the visit.
Actual time	The real time delivered, from check-in to check-out.
Time band	A part of the day with its own rate (morning, evening, night).
Visit splitting	Working out one visit in parts when it crosses time bands.
Reconciliation	The office confirming the final time to pay and to charge.
Travel time	Time spent travelling between visits.
Waiting time	Time waiting between visits, sometimes paid.
Mileage	Distance travelled, paid or charged per mile.

Funding

Term	Short definition
Funding contract	The record of who pays for a client's care and on what terms.
Split rule	How one visit's cost is shared between funders.
Percentage split	Sharing cost by fixed shares, e.g. 70% / 30%.
Fixed contribution	A set weekly amount from one payer, the rest from another.
Cap	A limit one funder pays up to, with another paying above it.
Priority	The order that tells the system which funder pays first.
PO number	A purchase order reference some funders require on invoices.

Billing and money out

Term	Short definition
Payroll run	Working out and grouping carer pay for a period, usually weekly.
Invoice run	Working out and grouping funder invoices for a period.
Invoice format	The layout a funder needs (standard, Local Authority, NHS).
Adjustment	An extra charge or correction added by hand, with a reason.
Credit note	A correction to an invoice that has already been sent.
Export	Sending figures to accounting software (Sage, Xero, QuickBooks, CM2000).
Direct Debit	An automatic way for a client to pay.

Control and quality

Term	Short definition
Status	The stage a visit, pay, or invoice is at (e.g. Draft, Approved, Locked).
Exception (flag)	Something missing or wrong that needs attention before approval.
Lock	Freezing a run so it can't be changed without permission.
Minimum wage check	A check that a carer's pay per hour meets the legal minimum.

Contents

1. What this module does
2. The main idea
3. How other care software does it
4. The whole flow, start to finish
5. How we pay the carer
6. How we charge the funder
7. Rate cards
8. Types of rate
9. Updating rates (uplift)
10. Special pay for one client (override)
11. Splitting one visit across time bands
12. Planned time vs actual time
13. When one client has more than one funder
14. Purchase orders and invoice formats
15. When a rate card is missing
16. Checking visits before billing
17. Payroll run
18. Invoice run
19. Cancellations and missed visits
20. Bank holidays
21. Mileage and travel
22. Minimum wage check
23. Sending invoices and getting paid
24. Statuses
25. Things to flag (exceptions)
26. Order of calculation
27. What to build first
28. Summary

(See Key terms above for definitions.)

1. What this module does

The Billing Module turns completed care visits into money records.

It answers two questions:

1. **How much do we pay the carer?**
2. **How much do we charge the funder** (the family, local authority, NHS, or private payer)?

These two numbers are always worked out **separately**.

---

2. The main idea

One completed visit creates **two** money lines:

```
Completed Visit
   → Carer pay line     (goes into payroll)
   → Invoice line       (goes to the funder)
```

The two amounts are usually different. The gap is the provider's margin.

Item	Amount
We pay the carer	£28
We charge the funder	£60
Margin	£32

---

3. How other care software does it

We looked at the main UK care platforms. They all work the same way, and our design already matches them:

- **Two rate cards per visit** — one for what the carer earns, one for what the funder pays.
- **One contract per funder** that copies the real paper agreement. The split rules are set once, not worked out again every time.
- **Verified check-in / check-out** is the trusted record of time.
- **Missing finance setup never stops care.** The visit is saved; the money side waits as a flag until someone fixes it.
- **Bulk rate changes** — one action updates a whole rate card.
- **Export and get paid** — send figures to accounting software and collect payment.

Quick view:

Platform	Worth copying
Birdie	Separate pay and invoice rates; split an invoice across funders; override a rate for one client; bulk uplift; NHS / Local Authority invoice formats.
The Access Group	App check-in feeds both pay and invoice; holiday pay auto-calculated; a pay button on invoices.
Nourish	Auto-creates invoices and timesheets from scheduled or recorded times.
CareLineLive	Many funders per contract; part-private / part-council split billing.
Nursebuddy	Pay by planned or actual time; pay for waiting time when the gap between visits is too big.

4. The whole flow, start to finish

```
Add carer
Add service user
Set up funding contract (who pays, how it splits)
Set up rate cards (pay + charge)
Schedule visits
Carer checks in and out
Visit completed
Office checks and approves the time
System works out pay and invoice
Run payroll  → send to accounting
Run invoices → split per funder, send out
Review anything flagged
Approve and lock
```

5. How we pay the carer

```
Carer → Pay rate card → Visit done → Time confirmed → Pay worked out → Weekly payroll
```

Example: Ayesha works 9:00 PM to 11:00 PM.

Time	Rate	Pay
9:00–10:00 PM (evening)	£13/hr	£13
10:00–11:00 PM (night)	£15/hr	£15
Total		**£28**

6. How we charge the funder

```
Service user → Funding contract → Charge rate card → Visit done → Time confirmed → Invoice worked out → Weekly invoices
```

Example: John Smith, funded by the Local Authority, 9:00 PM to 11:00 PM.

Time	Rate	Charge
9:00–10:00 PM (evening)	£28/hr	£28
10:00–11:00 PM (night)	£32/hr	£32
Total		**£60**

7. Rate cards

A rate card is just a set of rules for working out money. There are two kinds.

Pay rate card — what the carer earns. Linked to the carer, their role, or their contract.

Rule	Rate
Weekday morning	£12/hr
Weekday evening	£13/hr
Night	£15/hr
Weekend	£14/hr
Bank holiday	2×

Charge rate card — what the funder pays. Linked to the service user, funder, or contract.

Rule	Rate
Personal care (weekday)	£25/hr
Personal care (weekend)	£30/hr
Waking night	£180 fixed
Bank holiday	2×

8. Types of rate

A rate card can price a visit in a few different ways:

Type	Meaning	Example
Hourly	A rate for each hour.	£25/hour
By visit length	A set price for the whole visit, based on how long it is.	30 min = £18, 60 min = £30
Fixed	One set price for a block of care.	Sleeping night = £180
By service type	A rate for a type of care.	Complex care = £32/hr
Travel / mileage	Paid or charged for distance or time travelled.	£0.45/mile
Holiday	An extra rate or a multiplier on holidays.	Bank holiday 2×

> If a visit is longer than the longest "by visit length" band and there is no hourly rate to fall back on, the system should **flag it** — not charge £0.

---

9. Updating rates (uplift)

Rates change every year. Instead of editing each rule by hand, an admin can raise a **whole rate card by a percentage** in one step.

```
Pick rate card → Enter % (e.g. 5%) → Preview → Apply from a chosen date
```

Old visits keep the old rate. New visits use the new one. The change reaches every contract and carer linked to that card.

---

10. Special pay for one client (override)

Don't create a separate pay card for every client. That gets impossible to manage:

```
100 carers × 300 clients = 30,000 combinations
```

If a carer needs extra pay for one client (complex care, high-risk, tricky location), use an **override** on top of the base rate:

Item	Amount
Base pay	£12/hr
Complex care top-up	£3/hr
Final pay	**£15/hr**

The same works on the charge side if a funder has agreed a special rate for one client.

11. Splitting one visit across time bands

A visit stays **one visit**, but the money can be worked out in parts.

Visit: 9:00 PM to 11:00 PM.

Time	Rate	Amount
9:00–10:00 PM (evening)	£13/hr	£13
10:00–11:00 PM (night)	£15/hr	£15

One visit, two lines. Simple.

12. Planned time vs actual time

Pay and charge can be based on different times.

Basis	Means	Often used for
Actual	The real check-in / check-out time.	Paying the carer
Planned	The scheduled visit length.	Charging the funder

Example:

	Time
Planned	7:00–8:00 AM (60 min)
Actual	7:04–8:02 AM (58 min)
Pay based on	58 min (actual)
Charge based on	60 min (planned)

You can set which basis to use per funder.

13. When one client has more than one funder

One client can be paid for by several funders at once — Local Authority, NHS, family, or a private top-up.

You set up a **funding contract** with **split rules**, and the system does the rest. There are four common ways to split:

By percentage

Funder	Share	From £100
Local Authority	70%	£70
NHS	20%	£20
Family	10%	£10

Fixed weekly amount — family pays £40/week, the council pays the rest.

From a £300 week	Amount
Family	£40
Local Authority	£260

By service type — the council pays for personal care, the NHS pays for complex care, the family pays for extra hours.

With a cap — the council pays up to a limit, the family pays anything above it.

Council cap £250, week is £320	Amount
Local Authority	£250
Family	£70

You can also give funders a **priority order**, so the system knows who pays first.

---

14. Purchase orders and invoice formats

Councils and the NHS often need invoices in a certain format, and many will **reject an invoice that has no purchase order (PO) number** — "no PO, no payment."

So the system should:

- Store a **PO number** on the funding contract and print it on the invoice.
- Support different invoice layouts: **standard, Local Authority, and NHS**.
- **Flag** any funder that needs a PO but doesn't have one.

You can also add extra charges to an invoice — admin fees, shopping, or a one-off adjustment — each with a reason.

---

15. When a rate card is missing

Never stop care because finance setup is missing. Save the visit and flag the money side.

No pay rate card:

```
Visit done → No pay rate → Flag raised → Admin adds rate → Pay recalculated
```

No charge rate card:

```
Visit done → No charge rate → Flag raised → Admin adds rate/contract → Invoice recalculated
```

The visit stays "Completed." Only the money waits.

---

16. Checking visits before billing

Before payroll and invoicing, office staff check each visit and confirm the final time to pay and the final time to charge (which can be different).

	Time
Planned	7:00–8:00 AM
Actual	7:04–8:02 AM
Approved for pay	58 min
Approved for charge	60 min

---

17. Payroll run

Working out carer pay for a week.

```
Pick the week → Pick carers → Generate draft → Review flags → Approve → Lock → Export
```

Example lines:

Carer	Client	Type	Hours	Rate	Pay
Ayesha	John	Morning	1	£12/hr	£12
Ayesha	Peter	Waking night	9	£15/hr	£135

---

18. Invoice run

Working out invoices for a week.

```
Pick the week → Pick funders → Generate draft → Review flags → Approve → Lock → Send
```

Example lines:

Client	Funder	Type	Hours	Rate	Charge
John	Local Authority	Personal care	5	£25/hr	£125
John	Family	Private top-up	2	£30/hr	£60

19. Cancellations and missed visits

What happened	Pay	Charge
Cancelled more than 24h before	No pay	No charge
Cancelled less than 24h before	Maybe part/full pay	Maybe part/full charge
Carer arrived, client not available	Pay carer	Charge if contract allows
Carer missed the visit	No pay	No charge (may need an incident report)

20. Bank holidays

Keep a holiday calendar (Christmas, Boxing Day, New Year, bank holiday Mondays). Holidays can use a higher rate or a multiplier.

Normal	Multiplier	Holiday rate
£12/hr	2×	£24/hr

21. Mileage and travel

Set these separately for pay and charge.

Item	Carer pay	Funder charge
Mileage	Paid at £0.45/mile	Usually not charged
Travel time	Paid	Usually not charged
Waiting time	Paid after approval	Charged only if allowed

You can also choose whether to pay for the drive from home to the first visit, and whether to pay for waiting time only when the gap between visits is long enough.

22. Minimum wage check

Home care shifts have lots of short visits and gaps, so carers can slip below the legal minimum once travel and waiting time count.

The system should:

- Count travel and waiting time in total paid hours.
- **Warn** if a carer's total pay per hour falls below the National Minimum / Living Wage.
- Let an admin add a recorded top-up to fix it.

23. Sending invoices and getting paid

- **Export** payroll and invoices as CSV or PDF for Sage, Xero, QuickBooks, or CM2000.
- Let clients pay by **Direct Debit** or a **payment link** on the invoice.
- Mark invoices **Paid, Part Paid, or Overdue** automatically.
- Use a **credit note** to correct an invoice that's already been sent.

24. Statuses

Visit: Scheduled → In Progress → Completed → Reconciled (or Cancelled / Missed)

Pay: Not Ready → Rate Missing → Calculated → Approved → Locked

Invoice: Not Ready → Rate Missing → Funding Missing → PO Missing → Calculated → Approved → Locked

25. Things to flag (exceptions)

Show these clearly before anyone approves payroll or invoices:

- Pay rate card missing
- Charge rate card missing
- Funding contract missing
- PO number missing
- Visit not completed or no check-out
- Two visits overlap
- Visit longer than the longest band with no hourly fallback
- Rate override used

- Time changed by hand
- Split doesn't add up to the total
- Carer pay below minimum wage

---

26. Order of calculation

For each completed visit, the system should:

1. Confirm the visit is done and checked.
2. Get the approved pay time and charge time.
3. Find the carer's pay rate (or override).
4. Find the funder's charge rate (or override).
5. Check the service type, day, and time of day.
6. Split the visit across time bands if needed.
7. Apply the right rate (hourly, by length, fixed, or by service type).
8. Add mileage and travel.
9. Apply cancellation rules if needed.
10. Apply the funding split.
11. Check the PO number.
12. Run the minimum wage check.
13. Create the pay line and the invoice lines.
14. Flag anything missing.

---

27. What to build first

Must have

- Pay rate cards and charge rate cards
- Hourly and by-length rates
- Funding contracts
- One funder, and many funders with a percentage split
- Weekly payroll and weekly invoices
- Flags for missing rate cards
- Visit checking (planned vs actual)
- Check-in / check-out feeding the time
- Basic mileage and bank holiday rates

Should have

- Fixed and service-type rates
- Rate uplift tool
- Fixed weekly and service-based splits
- Time-band splitting
- Cancellation rules

- NHS / Local Authority invoice formats and PO numbers
- Export to CSV / PDF
- Manual adjustments with a reason

Later

- Caps and top-up logic
- Minimum wage warnings and top-ups
- Accounting integration (Sage, Xero, QuickBooks, CM2000)
- Direct Debit and payment tracking
- Credit notes
- Reports (profit per client)

---

28. Summary

```
One completed visit
   → work out carer pay
   → work out funder invoice
```

The key parts:

```
Pay rate card    = what the carer earns
Charge rate card = what the funder pays
Funding contract = who pays, and how it splits
Visit check      = the approved time
Payroll run      = groups the pay
Invoice run      = groups the charges
Flags            = missing or wrong setup
```

The golden rule:

```
Never block care.
If finance setup is missing, finish the visit and raise a flag.
```